



CONGRESS CRASHES OUT (From left clockwise) Bhupesh Baghel with Chhattisgarh governor B. Harichandan; Gehlot meets the press after loss in Rajasthan; MP in-charge Randeep Surjewala, Kamal Nath and Digvijay Singh introspect



ANI

What is even more disheartening for the Congress and the INDIA bloc is the failure of its biggest poll plank—the demand for a caste census. After Nitish upped the tempo by releasing the results of a caste survey in Bihar on October 2, the Congress had promised a caste survey in all poll-bound states. Rahul made it a central element in the party's poll discourse for 2024. The objective was to woo the OBC (Other Backward Classes) voter as their share in the population is believed to be much higher than the 52 per cent estimated by the Mandal Commission report based on the 1931 Census.

By raising the slogan of reservations proportionate to population, the Congress had hoped to wean away the OBC vote bank that has been the backbone of saffron victories in the Lok Sabha and assembly polls since 2014. However, the promise of a caste census proved insufficient lure in these assembly polls. More than half of the total OBC votes stood firmly behind the BJP in Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh. The Congress and its partners in INDIA now urgently need to unfurl a vision for the country that goes beyond caste. The BJP's Hindu identity politics backed by direct benefit welfare schemes may prove more potent than Mandal. INDIA was supposed to present a vision document on Gandhi Jayanti day at Raj Ghat in Delhi, focusing on farm distress, price rise and unemployment. That was put in cold storage, thanks to the assembly polls.

Both Congress and INDIA also face a leadership crisis in taking on Modi's seemingly teflon-coated popularity. In the last INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation survey in August, it was found that in a direct contest between Modi and Rahul, the Congress leader was far behind. While 52 per cent respondents felt that Modi is best suited to become the next prime minister, only 16 per cent backed Rahul. The latter's Bharat Jodo Yatra, touted as a game-changing political exercise, also did not yield the expected results in the three states it spent considerable time in. In Telangana, where it touched 29 constituencies, Congress won only 12. In MP, it traversed 21 assembly segments but won only four in the polls. Only in Rajasthan did it yield some dividend, with the Congress winning nine out of 12 assembly segments the yatra passed through. Six were already with the Congress, though.

Not surprisingly, the alliance partners are hesitant to accept Rahul as the prime ministerial face. The Congress has declared that it is open to the idea of a non-Congress leader becoming prime minister in the event of INDIA winning the 2024 election. Yet, there is no unanimity on nominating a challenger to Modi, perhaps because several of them—NCP chief Sharad Pawar, Mamata and Nitish—themselves harbour aspirations for the top job. Uncertainty over a face puts a question mark on the stability and direction of the anti-Modi collective, a liability in today's India, which has backed decisive mandates in the past few years. That's another puzzle the INDIA bloc must solve soon if it hopes to rule India in the summer of 2024. ■